DR. NIKITA MEHTA

BEFORE YOU CHANGE YOUR SMILE

What I'd want you to know before you sit in anyone's chair



ALIGNMENT, TWO VENEERS AND BONDING · MY OWN CASE

Wanting to change your smile is a valid choice, at any age and for any reason, including how it makes you feel. There are a lot of treatments and a lot of opinions out there. This short guide covers how to get clear on what you want, how to choose who does it, and how to look after the result.

01 KNOW WHAT YOU'D LIKE

02 CHOOSE YOUR DENTIST

03 LOOK AFTER YOUR SMILE

STEP 1

KNOW WHAT *you'd like*

DR. NM

Before you speak to any dentist, look at your smile properly, in the mirror and in a few photos you like of yourself. Then ask yourself three things.

i **WHAT DO I LIKE ABOUT MY SMILE?**

This matters as much as what you'd change. It tells your dentist what to protect.

ii **WHAT WOULD I CHANGE?**

It might be the colour, a chipped edge, small gaps, teeth that have worn down, or a smile that looks older than you feel.

iii **HOW DO I WANT IT TO FEEL?**

Most of my patients want to look like themselves on a good day. Some want a more noticeable change. Both are fine, as long as you know which one you're asking for.

Write it down, even in a few words. You don't need the technical terms. A clear sense of what you'd love and what you'd hate to lose makes your consultation far more useful.

> WORTH BRINGING
>
> Old photos of your smile, from five or ten years ago. When teeth are worn or broken down, I often use them to bring back the shape you had.

STEP 2

CHOOSE *your dentist*

DR. NM

This is the biggest decision you'll make, so start with their work.

1 · THEIR OWN CASES, IN REAL PHOTOS

Ask to see before and after photos of cases the dentist has done themselves. They show you their standard and their style. If you love a dentist's work, you're far more likely to love your own result.

When I look at a finished smile, I ask one question: does it look like that person? Hardly any of my cases look the same, because every person comes in with their own arch, gums, bite and personality.



TRAUMA, INTERIM COMPOSITE AND FOUR CROWNS



TWO VENEERS AND BONDING · 10 YEARS ON



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING AND BONDING



VENEERS, CROWN AND BONDING · 5 YEARS ON

STEP 2, CONTINUED

WHAT ELSE TO *look for*

DR. NM

2 SOMEONE WHO STARTS WITH YOUR HEALTH

A good plan starts with your gums, your bite and the health of your teeth, and only then with how they look. If your bite won't allow long teeth, longer teeth are likely to chip or break. A dentist who tells you that is looking after you.

3 SOMEONE WHO OFFERS LESS, WHEN LESS IS RIGHT

Ask what your options are, including whitening, straightening, bonding, or doing nothing for now. Veneers are one option, not the only one. Be wary of a plan that only has one answer.

4 CARE AFTER THE FIT

Things occasionally come up: a chipped edge, a bite that feels different. Choose someone who checks in, explains openly and puts things right without fuss.

"Does it look like them? That's the question I ask of every smile I finish."

STEP 3

LOOK AFTER *your smile*

Whatever you choose, including nothing at all, these make a real difference.

BRUSH TWICE A DAY

With a fluoride toothpaste.

CLEAN BETWEEN YOUR TEETH

Floss or interdental brushes, every day.

CHECK-UPS

See your dentist and hygienist regularly.

A SIMPLE PLACE TO START

WHITENING

Dentist-prescribed whitening is one of the gentlest ways to refresh a smile, and it doesn't involve drilling or shaping your teeth. If you're thinking about bonding or veneers later, whitening usually comes first, so the new work is matched to your whitened shade.



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING AND COMPOSITE · MY OWN CASE

GOING FURTHER

WHEN YOU'D LIKE *more of a change*

DR. NM

COMPOSITE BONDING

Tooth-coloured composite is added to your teeth to repair chips, close small gaps and even out shape and length. It needs little or no shaping of your own tooth. In skilled hands it looks natural and shouldn't look bulky.



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING AND BONDING

VENEERS

A thin porcelain layer over the front of the tooth, for a bigger change to shape and colour that lasts. Veneers usually need some shaping of the tooth, and that is permanent, so they need real case selection.



TWO VENEERS AND COMPOSITE

CLEAR ALIGNERS

Removable aligners that straighten crowded or gappy teeth. Straightening first often means less composite or less shaping later, and a more natural result.



ALIGNMENT, WHITENING AND BONDING

TALK IT THROUGH

If you'd like to talk about your smile, book a consultation with me through my website.

BOOK A CONSULTATION

DRNIKITAMEHTA.COM

KEEP READING

I write *The Deliberate Clinician*, a free weekly letter on how I think about smiles, ageing and the work behind a natural result.

MEHTAN.SUBSTACK.COM

Dr Nikita Mehta · GDC 76510. This guide is general information, not advice for your teeth. Every smile is different, and your options depend on a proper examination. Photos are my own cases, shown with consent.